Activity 1: Babylist: Make an Intangible Service Easy to Trust

Objective: Explain the business impact and benefits of tangible service-brand proof
Expected output: One-page service-brand value map and prioritised proof plan Primary source: https://www.shopify.com/sg/blog/service-branding

Goal

Use Shopify's Babylist example to diagnose how a service brand reduces risk and creates a clear reason to choose.

Real-world scenario

Shopify presents Babylist as a service-brand example and describes service branding as building a recognisable identity and experience around an intangible offering.

A Singapore family-services platform combines consultations, curated recommendations and digital planning tools. Growth has slowed because prospects cannot see why the service is more valuable than free online advice.

Evidence boundary

Public case facts and fictional learner data must never be mixed. Every numerical or organisational training input is labelled as an assumption.

Training assumptions / guardrails

- The Singapore platform, customer interviews and commercial figures are fictional training inputs, not Babylist disclosures.
- Mock research shows first-time parents value reassurance, time saved and unbiased recommendations.
- The current landing page leads with features and has no process map, expert proof or outcome story.
- Management will fund one 90-day proof-building initiative before changing price.

Questions

1. Which functional, financial, time and social risks affect the customer's decision?
2. What brand benefits could matter to customers, employees and the business?
3. Which three tangible cues would make the promise easier to trust?
4. What is the defensible competitive advantage, and what evidence is still missing?

Detailed activity procedure

Step 1: Separate facts and assumptions

Read the source excerpt and label every statement about Babylist, the fictional platform and customer evidence.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Step 2: Define customer progress

Write the customer's job, pains, desired gains and purchase risk in one concise problem statement.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Step 3: Map brand impact

Connect a clear promise to credible proof, customer response and commercial outcome without claiming unsupported causality.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Step 4: Inventory existing cues

Score process visibility, expert evidence, outcome stories, reviews, assurance and service recovery from 1 to 5.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Step 5: Design proof

Select three cues and specify content, owner, touchpoint and the uncertainty each cue reduces.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Step 6: State the advantage

Write one relevant, distinctive and deliverable competitive-advantage statement plus the evidence needed to validate it.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Deliverable

One-page service-brand value map and prioritised proof plan

Acceptance criteria

The submission separates facts from assumptions, links at least three proof cues to customer risk and business benefit, and states a defensible advantage with validation evidence.

Reflection and debrief questions

1. Which customer or employee insight changed your recommendation most, and why?
2. What evidence would you request before investing or scaling?
3. Which stakeholder owns the next service-brand decision?
4. What should the organisation start, stop or continue?

Facilitator debrief

Compare recommendations against relevance, distinctiveness, deliverability and evidence quality. Surface unsupported causal claims. Close by naming one decision, one owner and one validation action.

Source note

Source accessed 17 August 2026: https://www.shopify.com/sg/blog/service-branding